BAL GOKUL · 2026–27 · GRADES 9–12

Sacred Geography

Student Handouts: activity sheets, quizzes and reflections

Name _____

Class teacher _____

Bring this packet, or the page for the day, to every class. Your reflections build into a passport of the year's journey.

What Makes a Place Sacred?

Your task: You have three minutes. Your group explains why its site is sacred using all three lenses: one story, one practice, one community. Then choose a speaker to make a 60-second case to the class.

Three-lens case card: my group's site is _____

Lens	Evidence from our site	Why it makes the place sacred
Narrative		
Practice		
Community		

Quick check

Narrative, practice or community? — write the group for each card

Groups: Narrative · Practice · Community

Card	Group
Kailash described as Shiva's abode	
Story of the Ganga descending from heaven	
Ritual bath at Har ki Pauri, Haridwar	
King Bhagiratha's penance brings the river to earth	
Evening Ganga aarti	
Walking the circuit around Kailash	
Boatmen families serving pilgrims for generations	
Haridwar priests keeping family genealogy registers	

Quiz — circle one letter

1. What did the word tirtha originally mean?

(A) A temple tower
(B) A royal decree
(C) A festival season
(D) A ford or river crossing

2. Which statement is emic (an insider description)?

(A) "For devotees, bathing at the Sangam washes away sins."
(B) "Pilgrimage boosts the regional economy."
(C) "The Ganga basin supports 400 million people."
(D) "Pilgrim numbers rise in winter."

3. At Haridwar, many priestly families are known for keeping…

(A) Genealogy registers of pilgrim families
(B) Weather logs
(C) Temple blueprints
(D) Tax records

4. Mount Kailash is sacred to which traditions?

(A) Only Hindu
(B) None; it is a climbing peak
(C) Hindu, Buddhist, Jain and Bon
(D) Only Buddhist

5. Which phrasing best fits academic writing?

(A) "Many Hindus regard the Ganga as a goddess."
(B) "Hindus worship rivers."
(C) "The Ganga is a goddess."
(D) "Everyone in India bathes in the Ganga."

Passport reflection

Write a thesis sentence: "A place becomes sacred when…" Support it with evidence from one of today's sites.

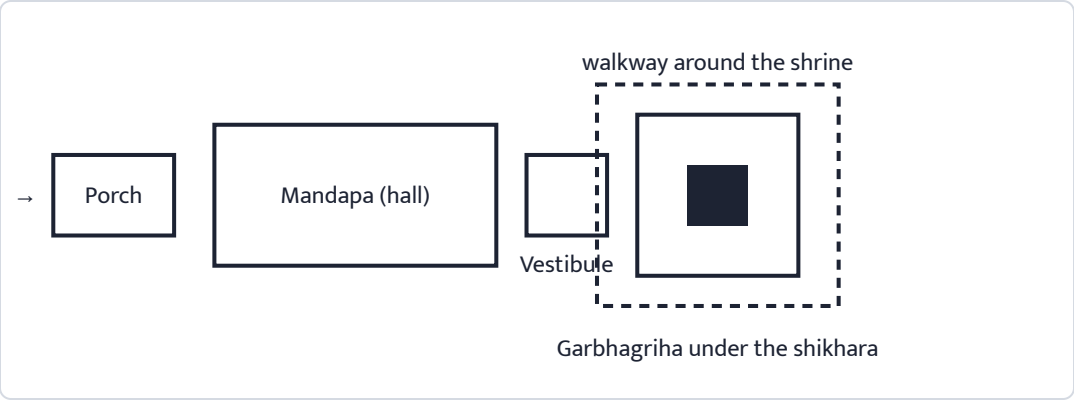
Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Inside a Hindu Temple

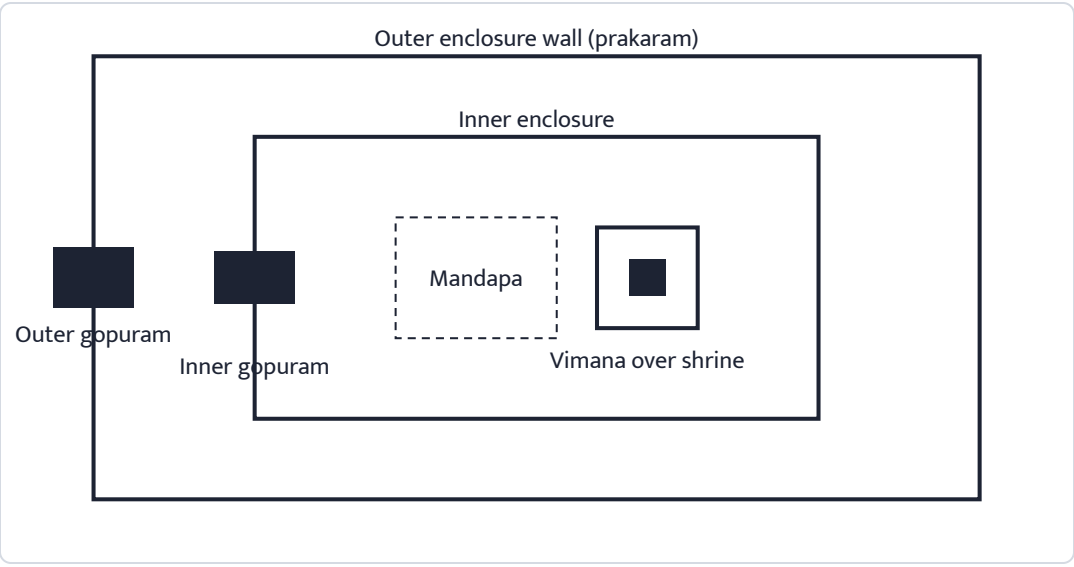
Your task: In pairs, compare the two floor plans on your sheet: one North Indian temple and one South Indian temple. Write three observations about how space, light and movement shape a visit. Use at least two of today's terms.

Plan A: a North Indian (Nagara) temple, schematic



Visitors move in a straight line from porch to shrine. Not to scale.

Plan B: a South Indian (Dravida) temple, schematic



Visitors pass through gateways and enclosures toward the center. Not to scale.

Three observations

Observation (space, light or movement)	Term used	Plan A or B?

Quick check

Match the terms — write the matching letter

	Item	Letter		Match
1	prasad		**A**	seeing and being seen by the deity
2	pradakshina		**B**	sacred image of a deity
3	mandapa		**C**	inner shrine room
4	garbhagriha		**D**	pillared hall for gathering
5	puja		**E**	worship with offerings
6	murti		**F**	food offered and returned as blessing
7	darshan		**G**	clockwise circling of the shrine

Order the spaces, outer to inner — number them in order

Order #	Step
	Gateway
	Mandapa (hall)
	Antarala (vestibule)
	Outer courtyard
	Garbhagriha (inner shrine)

Quiz — circle one letter

1. Why is the garbhagriha usually small and dim?

(A) It concentrates attention on the murti, the sacred center
(B) To store temple records
(C) Because lamps were banned
(D) To save building costs

2. Darshan is best described as…

(A) A silent prayer
(B) A dance form
(C) A temple tax
(D) A two-way exchange of sight between devotee and deity

3. Which texts give rules for temple proportions and plans?

(A) Arthashastra
(B) Panchatantra
(C) Ramayana
(D) Vastu and Shilpa Shastras

4. Pradakshina is performed…

(A) Counter-clockwise
(B) Only by priests
(C) Only at night
(D) Clockwise, keeping the shrine on the right

Passport reflection

Describe how one feature of temple design (path, light, tower or hall) shapes a visitor's experience. Use one specific term from today.

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Architecture Across Regions

Your task: Choose one temple from the slide. Argue whether it fits neatly into one style label or blends several. Give two visual details as evidence. You have four minutes; be ready to defend your choice.

Style detective

Temple	Tower shape	Gateway?	Built or carved?	My label (one or blended?)
Kandariya Mahadeva, Khajuraho				
Brihadisvara, Thanjavur				
Pattadakal group				
Lingaraja, Bhubaneswar				
Kailasa, Ellora				

My argument: does my chosen temple fit one label or blend several? Two visual details as evidence.

Quick check

Which style? — write the group for each card

Groups: Nagara · Dravida · Rock-cut

Card	Group
Curvilinear shikhara	
Brihadisvara, Thanjavur	
Stepped pyramidal vimana	
Kandariya Mahadeva, Khajuraho	
Lingaraja, Bhubaneswar (Kalinga variant)	
Kailasa temple, Ellora	
Shaped by removing stone only	
Monumental gateway gopurams	

Quiz — circle one letter

1. Which feature defines the Nagara style?

(A) A flat roof
(B) A curvilinear shikhara over the shrine
(C) Giant gateway towers
(D) Rock-cut halls

2. Why is Pattadakal important to architectural history?

(A) It has no carvings
(B) Northern and southern styles stand side by side
(C) It is the oldest temple
(D) It is made of wood

3. What made the Kailasa temple an engineering feat?

(A) It floats on water
(B) It was carved downward from one cliff
(C) It was built in a year
(D) It was assembled from metal

4. What is the strongest critique of style labels?

(A) The labels are too new
(B) They only apply to Nepal
(C) They are illegal
(D) Real temples often blend features across categories

Passport reflection

In two sentences, explain one strength and one limitation of classifying temples by style.

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

The Pilgrim's Journey

Your task: In groups of three, plan a family pilgrimage to any site we've mentioned. Decide on season, route, transport and budget, and how you will include an elderly grandparent. Then name one trade-off you had to make.

Family pilgrimage plan

Decision	Our choice	Reason
Destination		
Season / month		
Route and transport		
Estimated budget		
Plan for an elderly grandparent		
Environmental impact		

One trade-off we had to make:

Quick check

Stages of a pilgrimage — number them in order

Order #	Step
	Prepare (vow, packing, farewells)
	Darshan and rituals
	Remember and retell
	Share food and prasad
	Travel
	Return home
	Arrive

Turner's ideas or not? — write the group for each card

Groups: Fits liminality / communitas · Doesn't fit

Card	Group
Strangers share meals on the road	
Separate luxury tours from other pilgrims	
VIP darshan lines for paying visitors	
Social rank matters less during the journey	
Pilgrims wear simple, similar clothing	

Quiz — circle one letter

1. Turner used "communitas" to describe...

(A) A tax on pilgrims
(B) A shared sense of equality among pilgrims
(C) A sacred river
(D) A type of temple

2. Which is a liminal experience?

(A) Being between ordinary life and the destination
(B) Sleeping at home
(C) Shopping
(D) Paying a bill

3. Which is a common motive for pilgrimage?

(A) Earning a salary
(B) Fulfilling a vow
(C) Military service
(D) Avoiding school

4. Which development most changed access to pilgrimage sites?

(A) Telescopes
(B) Sundials
(C) Printing presses
(D) Modern transport such as railways and roads

Passport reflection

Answer with an example: how can a journey change a person, and does ease of travel change that?

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Reading Sources and Sacred Narratives

Your task: Your question is: "Why did pilgrims visit this temple in the 1100s?" Rank three sources from most to least useful: the temple's sthala purana, a royal inscription from 1120, and a modern travel blog. Justify each ranking with the source questions.

Three sources about a temple (classroom examples written for this activity)

Source A: Sthala purana (temple origin story)
"Long ago, a sage meditated beside this pond until the deity appeared in a column of light. Whoever bathes here on the full moon of Kartik is freed from their troubles." Retold by the temple priests; written down in its current form in the 1800s.

Source B: Royal inscription, dated 1120 CE
"In the 14th year of the king's reign, he granted the village of [name] to the temple so that lamps may burn day and night and food may be offered at the Kartik festival. Witnessed by the assembly." Carved on the temple's south wall.

Source C: Travel blog, 2024
"Bucket-list trip! The full-moon festival was packed, the lamps were magical and the street food was the best I've ever had. Tip: go early to skip the lines."

Rank the sources for the question: "Why did pilgrims visit this temple in the 1100s?"

Rank	Source	Who made it, when, why?	What it can't tell us
1			
2			
3			

Quick check

Source type — write the group for each card

Groups: Narrative · Object · Place · Image · Written record

Card	Group
A temple's sthala purana	
Bronze Nataraja	
Copper-plate land grant	
Ghats of Varanasi	
Mughal-era miniature painting	
19th-century photograph of a festival	
Al-Biruni's account of India	
Ramayana episode	

Quiz — circle one letter

1. A copper-plate land grant to a temple is best used to learn...

(A) Who funded the temple and what they gave
(B) The weather that year
(C) Modern visitor numbers
(D) Exact beliefs of every visitor

2. Historians treat sacred narratives as evidence of...

(A) Scientific facts
(B) Exact historical events
(C) What communities believed and valued
(D) Nothing useful

3. Why read colonial surveys critically?

(A) Their authors' assumptions shaped what they recorded
(B) They are always fake
(C) They are too short
(D) They were written in Sanskrit

4. What is a sthala purana?

(A) A dance
(B) A temple's local origin story
(C) A tax receipt
(D) A map

Passport reflection

Choose one source type and explain one question it can answer well and one it cannot.

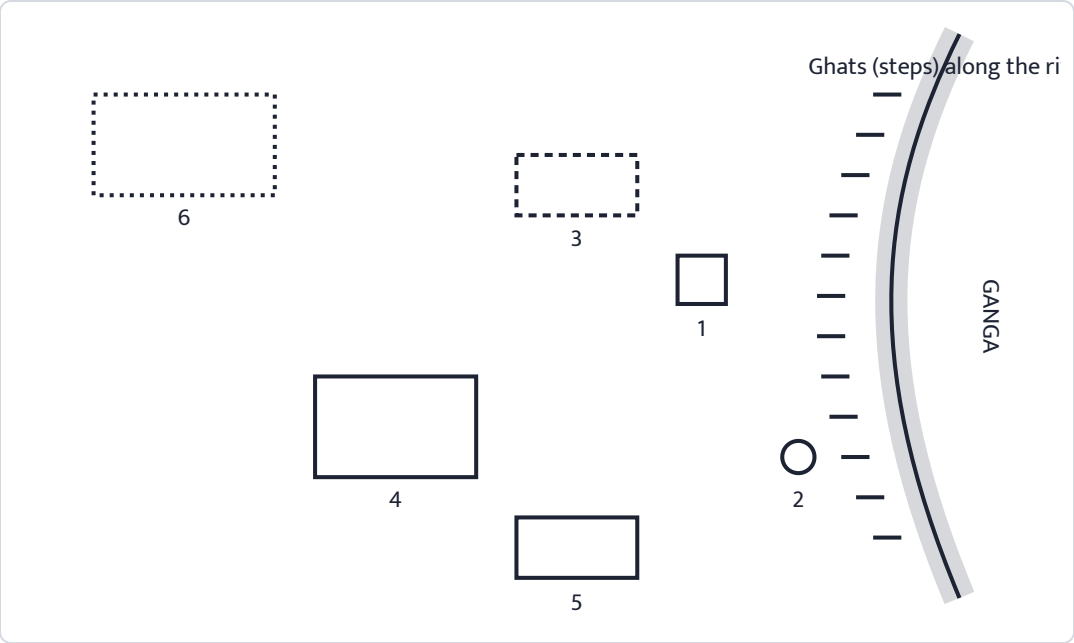
Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Varanasi and Kashi Vishwanath

Your task: In pairs, annotate the city map. Mark religious, residential and commercial spaces in three colors. Then find one place where they overlap and explain whether that overlap creates tension or harmony.

Varanasi, schematic (not to scale)



1 Kashi Vishwanath temple and corridor · 2 Manikarnika ghat · 3 Narrow lanes with shops · 4 Banaras Hindu University · 5 Silk weavers' neighborhood · 6 Newer residential areas. Color each: religious, residential, commercial.

One place where these overlap. Tension or harmony? Explain.

Should a sacred city prioritize pilgrims, residents or heritage? Argue, and include one counterargument.

Quick check

One city, many meanings — write the group for each card

Groups: Worship · Learning & arts · Work & trade · Life & death

Card	Group
Kashi Vishwanath	
Hindustani music gharanas	
Banaras Hindu University	
Boatmen ferrying visitors	
Cremation at Manikarnika ghat	
Banarasi silk looms	
Hospices for the dying	
Evening Ganga aarti	

From river to temple — number them in order

Order #	Step
	Boat on the Ganga at dawn
	Climb the ghat steps
	Walk the narrow lanes
	Darshan at Kashi Vishwanath
	Pass security and leave shoes

Quiz — circle one letter

1. Who built the present Kashi Vishwanath temple in 1780?

- (A) Ashoka
- (B) Queen Ahilyabai Holkar
- (C) Rajaraja Chola
- (D) Akbar

2. Why do many Hindus hope to die in Kashi?

- (A) For tax reasons
- (B) It is believed to grant moksha (liberation)
- (C) Medical care is free
- (D) It is the capital

3. What did the 2021 Kashi Vishwanath Corridor do?

- (A) Moved the temple
- (B) Built a dam
- (C) Closed the ghats
- (D) Linked the temple directly to the river ghats

4. What does the name Kashi mean?

- (A) City of light
- (B) Mountain city
- (C) City of rivers
- (D) Old town

Passport reflection

Argue in three sentences: should a sacred city prioritize pilgrims, residents or heritage? Acknowledge one counterargument.

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Prayagraj, Haridwar and the Kumbh Mela

Your task: You are the planning committee. You have money for only four of these six systems at full strength: water, sanitation, medical, bridges, waste, communications. Rank them and justify your top two. Then name one environmental and one safety trade-off of your plan.

Planning committee: rank the six systems (you can fully fund only four)

Rank	System	Why this rank?
	Clean water	
	Sanitation (toilets)	
	Medical care	
	Pontoon bridges	
	Waste collection	
	Communications and lost-and-found	

Trade-offs

Environmental trade-off	Safety trade-off

Quick check

Problem and system — write the matching letter

	Item	Letter		Match
1	Peak bathing-day crowd surge		**A**	Clean water and sanitation
2	Lost children and elders		**B**	Field hospitals
3	Tons of waste daily		**C**	Lost-and-found centers
4	Waterborne disease risk		**D**	Timed entry and one-way routes
5	Medical emergencies		**E**	Pontoon bridges
6	Crossing a wide river		**F**	Waste collection and segregation

Quiz — circle one letter

1. What determines Kumbh Mela timing?

(A) Positions of Jupiter, the sun and the moon
(B) Government elections
(C) Monsoon rainfall only
(D) The school calendar

2. Which story explains the four Kumbh cities?

(A) Krishna's birth
(B) The Mahabharata war
(C) Rama's journey
(D) Drops of amrita falling at four places

3. When did UNESCO recognize the Kumbh Mela?

(A) 1947
(B) 2025
(C) 2017
(D) 1990

4. What are akharas?

(A) Rivers
(B) Police units
(C) Tent hotels
(D) Orders of ascetics who lead the royal baths

Passport reflection

Name one joy and one danger of mass gatherings, and propose one evidence-based way to make them safer.

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Ayodhya, Mathura and Vrindavan

Your task: Read the two short passages on your sheet: a devotional description of Vrindavan and a historian's account of how Braj sites were identified. In pairs, list what each emphasizes and what each leaves out. Then write one sentence on why both are valuable.

Two passages about Vrindavan (classroom examples written for this activity)

Passage A: a devotional description

"In Vrindavan every grove still echoes with Krishna's flute. The dust of its lanes is so holy that pilgrims touch it to their foreheads. Here the cowherd boy played with his friends, and here the gopis searched for him through the night. To walk in Vrindavan is to walk inside his lila."

Passage B: a historian's description

"By the early 1500s, many Braj sites linked with Krishna had been forgotten or were little visited. Followers of Chaitanya and of Vallabhacharya traveled to the region, identified ponds, groves and hills with episodes from Krishna's life, and sponsored temples, some with support from Rajput nobles. Their work created the pilgrimage circuit visited today."

Compare

	Passage A	Passage B
Emphasizes		
Leaves out		
Kind of truth it offers		

Why are both valuable? One sentence.

Quick check

Place and story — write the matching letter

	Item	Letter		Match
1	Vrindavan		**A**	Krishna lifts a hill to shelter villagers
2	Mathura		**B**	River of Braj
3	Sarayu		**C**	Krishna's birth
4	Yamuna		**D**	Krishna's youth with the gopis
5	Ayodhya		**E**	Rama's capital and return
6	Govardhan		**F**	River of Ayodhya

Quiz — circle one letter

1. Which 16th-century movements helped revive Braj pilgrimage sites?

- (A) Followers of Chaitanya and Vallabhacharya
- (B) The Mughal army
- (C) British surveyors
- (D) Jain monks

2. Mathura and Vrindavan lie on which river?

- (A) Yamuna
- (B) Sarayu
- (C) Ganga
- (D) Godavari

3. What does lila mean in Krishna devotion?

- (A) A tax
- (B) Divine play
- (C) A procession cart
- (D) A temple wall

4. The best approach to a contested sacred site in class is…

- (A) Avoid all facts
- (B) Repeat social media claims
- (C) Pick a side
- (D) Separate the narrative, the historical evidence and the modern dispute

Passport reflection

Start Site Profile 1: choose a site and list three sources of different types you will use.

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Himalayan Sacred Landscapes

Your task: Design a low-impact itinerary for the Chota Char Dham using the elevation and season information on your sheet. Then propose one policy to protect the valleys, such as permits, daily caps or electric shuttles, and name who might object and why.

Chota Char Dham fact sheet (approximate)

Shrine	Deity	Elevation	Access	Usual season
Yamunotri	Goddess Yamuna	about 3,290 m	Trek of about 6 km from Janki Chatti	late Apr/May to Oct/Nov
Gangotri	Goddess Ganga	about 3,100 m	By road	late Apr/May to Oct/Nov
Kedarnath	Shiva	about 3,580 m	Trek of about 16 km from Gaurikund, or helicopter	late Apr/May to Oct/Nov
Badrinath	Vishnu	about 3,300 m	By road	late Apr/May to Nov

Notes

Monsoon (July–August) brings landslides and road closures. Elevations above 2,500 m can cause altitude sickness; plan rest days. Exact opening and closing dates are announced each year.

Our low-impact itinerary

Day(s)	Where	How we travel	Impact-reducing choice

Our policy proposal, and who might object:

Quick check

Chota Char Dham, west to east — number them in order

Order #	Step
	Gangotri
	Kedarnath
	Badrinath
	Yamunotri

Quiz — circle one letter

1. What disaster in 2013 reshaped debate about Himalayan pilgrimage?

- (A) An earthquake in Delhi
- (B) A cyclone in Gujarat
- (C) A drought in Kerala
- (D) The Kedarnath flood

2. Why can access to Kailash change from year to year?

- (A) It is underwater
- (B) It is privately owned
- (C) It moves
- (D) It depends on permits and India–China relations

3. Which traditions hold Kailash sacred?

- (A) Hindu, Buddhist, Jain and Bon
- (B) Only Hindu
- (C) Only Bon
- (D) None

4. What is "carrying capacity"?

- (A) How many visitors a place can safely support
- (B) A temple tax
- (C) Bus seating
- (D) The weight a mule can carry

Passport reflection

Turn in Site Profile 1. Write one paragraph: how do environment and borders shape Himalayan pilgrimage?

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

The All-India Char Dham

Your task: In groups, compare the all-India Char Dham with the Himalayan Chota Char Dham on four points: purpose, geography, deities, and who could realistically complete each in the past and today. Fill the comparison table on your sheet.

Compare the two circuits

	All-India Char Dham	Himalayan Chota Char Dham
Sites	Badrinath, Dwarka, Puri, Rameswaram	Yamunotri, Gangotri, Kedarnath, Badrinath
Purpose		
Geography		
Deities		
Who could complete it 100 years ago?		
Who can complete it today?		

Quick check

Which direction? — write the group for each card

Groups: North · West · East · South

Card	Group
Badrinath	
Rameswaram	
Puri	
Dwarka	

Site, deity, setting — write the matching letter

	Item	Letter		Match
1	Dwarka		**A**	Vishnu, Himalayan valley
2	Rameswaram		**B**	Jagannath, Bay of Bengal coast
3	Badrinath		**C**	Shiva, island in the Gulf of Mannar
4	Puri		**D**	Krishna, Arabian Sea coast

Quiz — circle one letter

1. Which philosopher does tradition link with the four dhams?

- (A) Kabir
- (B) Ramanuja
- (C) Adi Shankaracharya
- (D) Tulsidas

2. Which dham honors Shiva?

- (A) Badrinath
- (B) Puri
- (C) Dwarka
- (D) Rameswaram

3. Historians argue such circuits helped people…

- (A) Build railways
- (B) Avoid travel
- (C) Collect taxes
- (D) Imagine a connected sacred land

4. How does it differ from the Chota Char Dham?

- (A) It spans all four directions of India
- (B) It has no temples
- (C) It is all in one state
- (D) It is only for priests

Passport reflection

Explain in one paragraph what connects the four dhams beyond geography.

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Shiva and the Jyotirlinga Network

Your task: Choose one contested Jyotirlinga claim from the slide. Identify the competing sites, the kind of evidence each community points to, and explain why the dispute matters locally. Three minutes in pairs, then share.

Contested Jyotirlinga claims

Jyotirlinga	Competing sites
Vaidyanath	Deoghar (Jharkhand) · Parli (Maharashtra)
Nageshwar	Near Dwarka (Gujarat) · Aundha (Maharashtra) · Jageshwar (Uttarakhand)

My investigation

Question	Notes
Which claim did I choose?	
What evidence or tradition does each site cite?	
What would recognition bring a town?	
Why does the dispute matter locally?	

Is a rebuilt temple the same sacred place? Use Somnath as evidence.

Quick check

Coast, river or mountain? — write the group for each card

Groups: Seacoast · Riverbank · Mountains

Card	Group
Kashi Vishwanath	
Mahakaleshwar (Shipra river)	
Ramanathaswamy, Rameswaram	
Somnath	
Kedarnath	

Quiz — circle one letter

1. What does aniconic mean?

- (A) Not shaped like a human or animal figure
- (B) Very large
- (C) Made of wood
- (D) Painted gold

2. When was the present Somnath temple completed?

- (A) 2001
- (B) 1951
- (C) 1026
- (D) 1780

3. Which Jyotirlinga has rival claimants in Jharkhand and Maharashtra?

- (A) Vaidyanath
- (B) Somnath
- (C) Kedarnath
- (D) Kashi Vishwanath

4. Mahakaleshwar is in which city?

- (A) Ujjain
- (B) Mysuru
- (C) Patna
- (D) Pune

Passport reflection

Argue whether a rebuilt temple is the same sacred place. Use Somnath as evidence.

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Shakti Peethas and Goddess Traditions

Your task: Look at the seven Goddess shrines on your sheet, spread across five countries. Lists of Shakti Peethas differ: a shrine may appear in one tradition's list and not another's. In pairs, suggest at least two reasons lists might differ, such as region, sect, era or the politics of pilgrimage, and say which shrines show that sacred geography crosses modern borders.

Seven Goddess shrines often linked with Shakti Peetha traditions

Kamakhya — Guwahati, Assam, India
Hilltop temple above the Brahmaputra; a major Tantric center.

Kalighat — Kolkata, West Bengal, India
Temple of Kali beside an old channel of the Hooghly.

Vaishno Devi — Jammu, India
Cave shrine in the Trikuta mountains; included in some traditions' lists.

Kamakshi Amman — Kanchipuram, Tamil Nadu, India
Great Goddess temple of the south.

Hinglaj Mata — Balochistan, Pakistan
Cave shrine; draws a large annual pilgrimage.

Guhyeshwari — Kathmandu, Nepal
Near Pashupatinath on the Bagmati river.

Jessoreshwari — Satkhira, Bangladesh
Goddess temple in southwestern Bangladesh.

Two reasons lists of Shakti Peethas might differ:

Which shrines show that sacred geography crosses modern borders? What does that mean for pilgrims?

Quick check

Shrine and setting — write the matching letter

	Item	Letter		Match
1	Kalighat		**A**	Cave shrine in the Trikuta mountains
2	Kamakshi Amman		**B**	Kolkata, beside the old Hooghly channel
3	Vaishno Devi		**C**	Hilltop above the Brahmaputra, Tantric center
4	Kamakhya		**D**	Temple town of Kanchipuram

Quiz — circle one letter

1. Shakta traditions treat the Goddess as...

(A) Supreme divine power
(B) A historical queen
(C) A river only
(D) A minor helper

2. Why do Shakti Peetha counts vary (4 to 108)?

(A) They don't vary
(B) Different texts, regions and sects list different sites
(C) Temples move
(D) Typos

3. Which shrine is a major Tantric center?

(A) Kalighat
(B) Vaishno Devi
(C) Kamakhya
(D) Kamakshi Amman

4. How do scholars read the scattered-body story?

(A) As a battle record
(B) As a recipe
(C) As linking regional goddesses into one network
(D) As a medical text

Passport reflection

Answer: what does diversity within one tradition look like? Use evidence from today.

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Vishnu and Krishna Pilgrimage Centers

Your task: Build a systems diagram for a large temple. On the left, inputs: donations, food supplies, volunteers, staff. In the middle, processes: rituals, cooking, administration. On the right, outputs: meals, festivals, schools, records. Then circle one point of tension, such as who decides how donations are spent.

Temple systems diagram

Inputs	Processes	Outputs

One point of tension (circle it on your diagram) and why:

Quick check

Temple roles — write the matching letter

	Item	Letter		Match
1	Kitchen staff		**A**	Performs daily rituals
2	Temple board		**B**	Prepare prasad and free meals
3	Nadaswaram players		**C**	Music for rituals and processions
4	Mahout		**D**	Manages funds and administration
5	Archaka (priest)		**E**	Crowd guidance and food service
6	Volunteers		**F**	Cares for temple elephants

Quiz — circle one letter

1. What is the TTD?

- (A) A railway
- (B) A dance school
- (C) A political party
- (D) The trust that manages the Tirumala temple

2. Srirangam is closely associated with which teacher?

- (A) Ramanuja
- (B) Chaitanya
- (C) Kabir
- (D) Adi Shankaracharya

3. What is a hundi?

- (A) A gopuram
- (B) A drum
- (C) A vow
- (D) A temple offering box

4. What debate surrounds many large temples?

- (A) Who should control temple funds
- (B) Building height only
- (C) None
- (D) Whether to use electricity

Passport reflection

Begin Site Profile 2. Include a systems diagram for your chosen site.

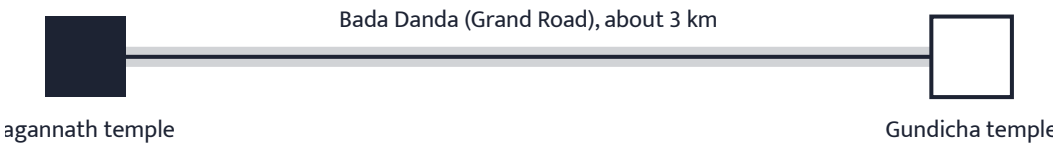
Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Festivals that Move the Deity

Your task: Choose one festival and plan its crowd management on the route map on your sheet. Mark entry points, medical stations, water points and how you'll communicate with the crowd. Then write two sentences explaining what the festival means to participants.

Example route: Puri Rath Yatra (schematic)



Use this route or sketch your own festival's route below. Mark entry points (E), medical stations (+), water (W) and announcement points (A).

Sketch or notes for your route plan:

What this festival means to participants (two sentences):

Quick check

Festival and feature — write the matching letter

	Item	Letter		Match
1	Rath Yatra		**A**	A divine wedding joined with a river procession
2	Chithirai Festival		**B**	Three wooden chariots rebuilt yearly
3	Karthigai Deepam		**C**	A three-week walk singing abhangs
4	Pandharpur Wari		**D**	A great lamp on Arunachala hill

Quiz — circle one letter

1. Which English word comes from Jagannath?

(A) Juggernaut
(B) Jungle
(C) Jaguar
(D) Journey

2. Which saints' palkhis lead the Wari?

(A) Mirabai and Surdas
(B) Basava and Allama
(C) Dnyaneshwar and Tukaram
(D) Tulsidas and Kabir

3. What does the Chithirai Festival unite?

(A) Two languages
(B) Two states
(C) Shaiva and Vaishnava festivals
(D) Hindu and Christian holidays

4. Why is the Wari socially significant?

(A) It excludes women
(B) It is open to people of all castes
(C) It is only for priests
(D) It is held online

Passport reflection

Explain why a sacred image might travel outside a temple, and what that reveals about community.

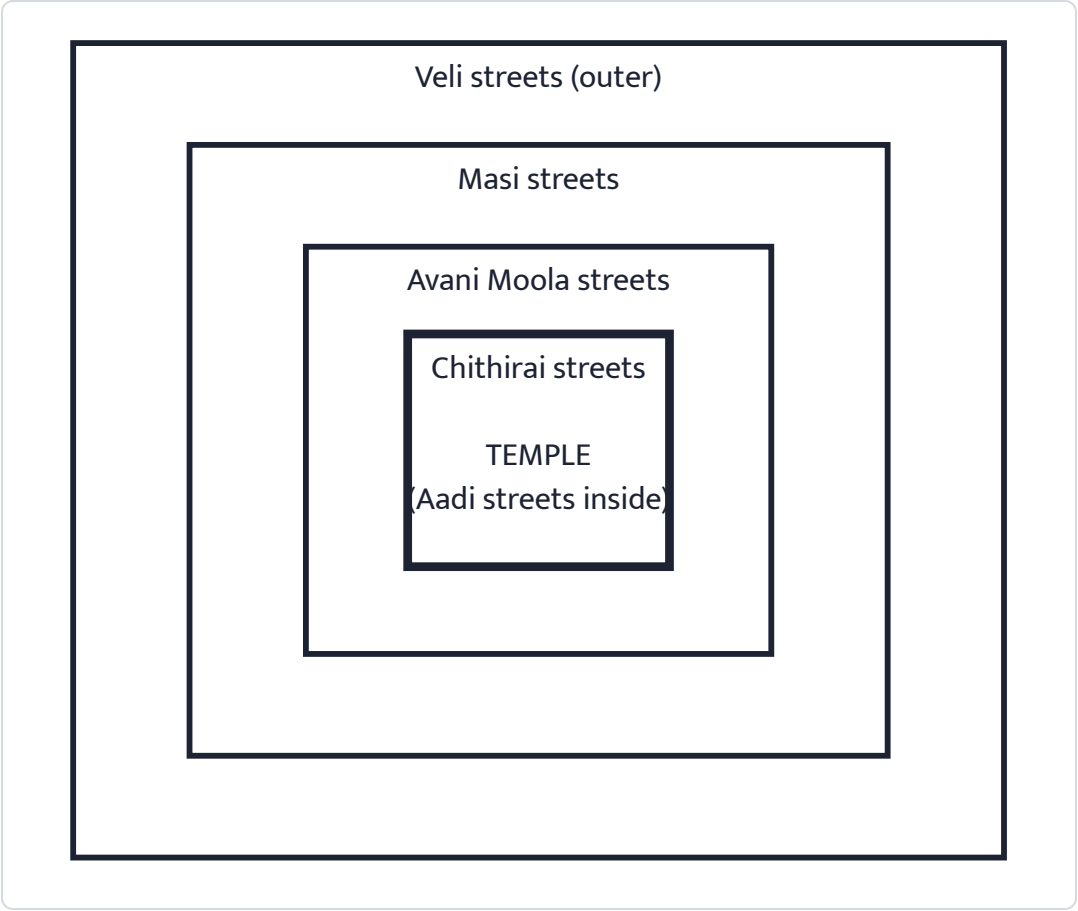
Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Madurai Meenakshi and the Temple-City

Your task: Use the simplified Madurai plan on your sheet. Mark the temple, the gateways, one market and one procession street. Then explain in three sentences how the plan supports both worship and business, and compare it with Washington, D.C., which is planned around the Capitol and the National Mall.

Old Madurai, schematic (not to scale)



Concentric streets around the Meenakshi temple, named after Tamil months. Mark: four gateways, one market, one procession route.

How does the plan support both worship and business? (three sentences)

Madurai and Washington, D.C.

	Madurai	Washington, D.C.
What sits at the center?		
Where do processions or parades go?		
What does the plan say matters most?		

Quick check

Inside the walls or the streets? — write the group for each card

Groups: Inside the temple · City streets around it

Card	Group
Meenakshi's shrine	
Thousand Pillar Hall	
Golden Lotus Tank	
Flower markets	
Tailors and brass shops	
Month-named procession streets	

Quiz — circle one letter

1. Which dynasty built much of the present Meenakshi temple?

- (A) The Mauryas
- (B) The British
- (C) The Mughals
- (D) The Nayaks

2. Madurai's street names come from...

- (A) Rivers
- (B) Numbers
- (C) Kings
- (D) Tamil months

3. Gopuram figures are made of...

- (A) Glass
- (B) Wood
- (C) Painted stucco
- (D) Gold

4. The city plan resembles a...

- (A) Grid of numbered avenues
- (B) Spiral
- (C) Random maze
- (D) Mandala of concentric squares

Passport reflection

Identify three design features of a gopuram and explain what each communicates to a visitor.

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Thanjavur, Chidambaram and Temple Arts

Your task: Make a claim about how the Brihadisvara temple served Rajaraja's political power. Support it with two pieces of evidence from today: its scale, its inscriptions, its location in the capital, or anything else. Write it as a short paragraph.

Claim and evidence: Brihadisvara and royal power

My claim	
Evidence 1	
Evidence 2	
How the evidence supports the claim	

Should sacred bronzes in foreign museums return to India's temples? Give your view and one counterargument.

Quick check

Read the Nataraja — write the matching letter

	Item	Letter		Match
1	Ring of fire		**A**	Sound of creation
2	Damaru drum		**B**	Release and grace
3	Abhaya hand (raised palm)		**C**	Destruction and transformation
4	Fire in one hand		**D**	Protection, "do not fear"
5	Foot on the dwarf Apasmara		**E**	Overcoming ignorance
6	Raised foot		**F**	The cosmos and its cycles

Quiz — circle one letter

1. Who built Brihadisvara?

- (A) Rajaraja Chola I
- (B) Krishnadevaraya
- (C) Ashoka
- (D) Ahilyabai Holkar

2. Why are its inscriptions valuable to historians?

- (A) They record gifts, staff and pay
- (B) They are poems only
- (C) They predict the future
- (D) They list modern visitors

3. How were Chola bronzes made?

- (A) Printed
- (B) Carved from wood
- (C) Lost-wax casting
- (D) Woven

4. What does repatriation mean?

- (A) Returning objects to their place of origin
- (B) Rebuilding
- (C) Repainting
- (D) Renaming

Passport reflection

Make one claim about the Nataraja and support it with two visible details.

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Rameswaram and the Sea

Your task: Evaluate the Sethusamudram debate. In groups of three, each person takes one position: economic, environmental or religious. Summarize your position and the evidence it relies on in two minutes. Then together, write one sentence on whether these positions can be reconciled.

The Sethusamudram debate

Position	Main argument	Evidence it relies on
Economic		
Environmental		
Religious		

Can these positions be reconciled? One sentence.

Quick check

Story map or physical map? — write the group for each card

Groups: Narrative · Physical / scientific

Card	Group
Bridge built by Hanuman's army	
Coral reefs of the Gulf of Mannar	
Sandbanks across the Palk Strait	
Rama worships Shiva	
Pamban vertical-lift bridge	
Hanuman brings a linga from Kailash	

Quiz — circle one letter

1. What is Adam's Bridge?

- (A) A chain of shoals between India and Sri Lanka
- (B) A temple gate
- (C) A steel bridge
- (D) A mountain pass

2. What was the Sethusamudram project?

- (A) A railway
- (B) A temple festival
- (C) A proposed shipping canal through the shoals
- (D) A dam

3. How many tirthams are inside Ramanathaswamy?

- (A) 108
- (B) 22
- (C) 4
- (D) 12

4. Rameswaram is located on…

- (A) Pamban Island
- (B) Andaman Islands
- (C) Majuli
- (D) Elephanta Island

Passport reflection

Answer: how can one place connect several stories and kinds of knowledge? Use Rameswaram as evidence.

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Hampi, Ellora, Khajuraho and Konark

Your task: You are museum curators. Choose four of the eight image cards on your sheet for a mini-exhibit. Decide one claim your exhibit makes, about art, power or landscape. Write a 50-word wall label for each image that supports your claim.

Eight image cards (choose four)

1. Hampi: stone chariot, Vittala temple
A carved granite shrine shaped like a chariot, 16th century.

2. Hampi: Virupaksha gopuram
A tall gateway tower rising over the bazaar street; still a living temple.

3. Ellora: Kailasa temple from above
A full temple carved down into a basalt cliff, 8th century.

4. Ellora: Buddhist Cave 10
A prayer hall with a ribbed ceiling and a seated Buddha.

5. Khajuraho: Kandariya Mahadeva
Tall Nagara towers rising like a mountain range, c. 1030.

6. Khajuraho: wall sculptures
Bands of carved deities, musicians and celestial dancers.

7. Konark: chariot wheel
One of 24 carved stone wheels of the Sun Temple, 13th century.

8. Konark: ruins by the coast
The surviving hall of the Sun Temple; the main tower has collapsed.

My mini-exhibit

Image #	50-word wall label

My exhibit's claim (one sentence):

Quick check

Site and clue — write the matching letter

	Item	Letter		Match
1	Khajuraho		**A**	Hindu, Buddhist and Jain caves together
2	Konark		**B**	Chandela temples, about 25 survive
3	Hampi		**C**	Sun temple shaped as a chariot
4	Ellora		**D**	Empire capital sacked in 1565

Quiz — circle one letter

1. Which battle led to Hampi's fall?

(A) Haldighati, 1576
(B) Talikota, 1565
(C) Plassey, 1757
(D) Panipat, 1526

2. Ellora is notable for...

(A) Hindu, Buddhist and Jain caves side by side
(B) Underwater shrines
(C) Wooden temples
(D) Only Jain caves

3. Which of these remains a living temple?

(A) All of them
(B) Virupaksha, Hampi
(C) Konark Sun Temple
(D) Ellora Cave 16

4. Who built the Konark Sun Temple?

(A) Narasimhadeva I
(B) Krishnadevaraya
(C) Ashoka
(D) Rajaraja I

Passport reflection

State the one-sentence claim of your exhibit and defend your choice of images.

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Beyond India: Bali, Cambodia and the Global Hindu World

Your task: Write a comparison of Angkor Wat and a Hindu temple in the US, such as one you know locally. Identify two continuities and two changes, and explain what caused each change: climate, materials, community needs, or laws.

Angkor Wat and a US Hindu temple

	Angkor Wat	A US temple: _____
Continuity 1		
Continuity 2		
Change 1 (and its cause)		
Change 2 (and its cause)		

Quick check

Bali or Angkor Wat? — write the group for each card

Groups: Bali · Angkor Wat

Card	Group
Mother Temple on a volcano	
Towers representing Mount Meru	
Daily canang sari offerings	
Appears on a national flag	
Built by Suryavarman II	
Temple on a sea rock	

Quiz — circle one letter

1. Angkor Wat was first dedicated to…

(A) Brahma
(B) Shiva
(C) Vishnu
(D) Ganesha

2. What is Agama Hindu Dharma?

(A) Balinese Hinduism
(B) An Indian temple
(C) A Cambodian dance
(D) A text

3. How did Indic religion reach Southeast Asia?

(A) Trade, royal courts and religious specialists
(B) Colonial missionaries
(C) The internet
(D) Military conquest by India

4. Angkor Wat's towers symbolize…

(A) The Ganga
(B) A chariot
(C) A lotus pond only
(D) Mount Meru

Passport reflection

Turn in Site Profile 2. Write one example of continuity and one of change in Hindu sacred spaces abroad.

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Temple Communities, Food and Service

Your task: Draft five respectful questions you could ask a local temple volunteer about how their temple runs. Then sketch a community web: put the temple in the center and connect at least eight roles, adding the resources each needs and one challenge they face.

Five respectful interview questions for a temple volunteer

Community web

Role	Resources they need	One challenge they face

Quick check

Roles and resources — write the matching letter

	Item	Letter		Match
1	Musician		**A**	Time and skills
2	Flower vendor		**B**	Garlands and supply chains
3	Archaka		**C**	Budgets and records
4	Administrator		**D**	Rituals, lamps and bells
5	Volunteer		**E**	Large kitchens and ingredients
6	Cook		**F**	Nadaswaram and drums

Quiz — circle one letter

1. What does seva mean?

(A) A tax
(B) A ritual bath
(C) Paid labor
(D) Selfless service

2. What is annadanam?

(A) A drum
(B) A gate
(C) A dance
(D) Free shared meals

3. What do US diaspora temples often rely on?

(A) Government funding
(B) Hereditary kings
(C) Tourism only
(D) Volunteers

4. What debate surrounds some temple roles?

(A) Whether they should be hereditary or open
(B) None
(C) Whether to use lamps
(D) Whether to serve food

Passport reflection

Explain why a sacred place needs many kinds of work, and name one form of labor people often overlook.

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Etiquette, Heritage and Sustainable Pilgrimage

Your task: First, sort the visitor choices on your sheet into respectful, ask first and not appropriate. Then join the heritage council: your group chooses one site and one problem, such as plastic, overcrowding or water pollution, and writes a one-page recommendation that names the trade-off and who bears its costs.

Heritage council recommendation

Our site	
The problem	
Our recommendation	
The trade-off	
Who bears the cost?	
How visitors will learn about it	

Quick check

Visitor choices — write the group for each card

Groups: Respectful · Ask first · Not appropriate

Card	Group
Follow signs on photography	
Photograph the inner shrine	
Remove shoes where asked	
Accept prasad with care	
Climb carvings for a selfie	
Join a ritual	
Touch the murti uninvited	
Leave plastic by the river	

Quiz — circle one letter

1. What is the best approach when rules are unclear?

- (A) Read signs and ask a volunteer
- (B) Do whatever you like
- (C) Copy tourists
- (D) Leave immediately

2. When was Namami Gange launched?

- (A) 2014
- (B) 2024
- (C) 1985
- (D) 1947

3. Which is intangible heritage?

- (A) Ellora caves
- (B) Hampi ruins
- (C) The Konark temple
- (D) The Kumbh Mela

4. A key tension in heritage management is…

- (A) Protecting monuments while allowing living worship
- (B) Selling tickets
- (C) Choosing paint colors
- (D) None

Passport reflection

State your recommendation in one sentence and name its main trade-off.

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Capstone Workshop

Your task: Check off every requirement on your checklist. Then trade exhibits with a partner. Give them one strength, one question and one specific fix. You have five minutes for checking and four for peer review.

Peer review

One strength	One question	One specific fix

My thesis (one arguable sentence):

My three sources

#	Source and type	What I use it for
1		
2		
3		

Quick check

Exhibit checklist

☐ Clear thesis

☐ Location map

☐ Timeline

☐ Architecture or landscape analysis

☐ One present-day issue

☐ Three credible sources, cited

☐ Credited images

☐ Respectful, accurate language

Quiz — circle one letter

1. Which sentence best fits an exhibit label?

(A) "In this tradition, the river is honored as a goddess."
(B) "Everyone believes this."
(C) "Hindus always do this."
(D) "All Hindus worship rivers."

2. Which source is most credible for site history?

(A) A rumor
(B) A meme
(C) An anonymous comment
(D) UNESCO World Heritage Centre

3. How should a temple's own website be used?

(A) As an emic source on beliefs and practices
(B) As a weather source
(C) As useless
(D) As neutral history

4. A strong thesis is…

(A) A list of facts
(B) A title
(C) A question only
(D) A specific, arguable claim

Passport reflection

Write your exhibit thesis and list your three sources.

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____

Exhibition, Reflection and Synthesis

Your task: During the museum walk, visit at least four exhibits. Leave a compliment and a question at each. Back at your seat, write your synthesis paragraph.

Synthesis organizer

Region	Example site	Narrative, practice or community evidence

One similarity and one difference across my examples:

My October thesis vs. my thesis today. What changed and why?

Quick check

Quiz — circle one letter

1. What did tirtha originally mean?

- (A) A ford or river crossing
- (B) A chariot
- (C) A drum
- (D) A tower

2. Emic describes...

- (A) The outsider's analysis
- (B) The insider's perspective
- (C) A river
- (D) A building style

3. Which site was carved from a single cliff?

- (A) Konark
- (B) Kedarnath
- (C) Meenakshi
- (D) Kailasa temple, Ellora

4. Who built the Brihadisvara temple?

- (A) Rajaraja Chola I
- (B) Ahilyabai Holkar
- (C) Suryavarman II
- (D) Narasimhadeva I

5. Angkor Wat was first dedicated to...

- (A) Buddha
- (B) Shiva
- (C) Vishnu
- (D) Surya

Passport reflection

Final reflection: something I learned, something I still wonder, and one principle for studying religion respectfully.

Exit ticket

One word for today's place: _____ One question I still have: _____